Church and State

By Jason Odell Williams

Suggested Roles: ***ACTOR:*** *Charlie, Reporter* ***ACTRESS:*** *All Other Roles*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

CHARLIE (VO): **(Pg 9)** *(on TV)* I'm Charles Whitmore and I approve this message. *(Lights rise as the campaign commercial continues)*

COMMERCIAL VOICE: He's been hailed as "a compassionate conservative," and "just the kind of leadership from 'The Right' that Washington needs." As senator, he championed the biggest welfare reform bill in our nation's history, voted to extend benefits for seniors and veterans, and protected our Second Amendment Rights by helping to block a restrictive ban on firearms. *(After a beat, Charlie enters quietly a little unsure of himself)* He's a family man who believes in good Christian values. The kind of values on which this country was founded. This Tuesday, help continue the grand tradition of Whitmores in North Carolina politics, and re-elect Senator Charles Whitmore. *(Charlie watches his commercial, mouthing along with the final catchphrase "the right leadership for a bold state" looking pleased and dissatisfied at the same time)* The right leadership for a bold state.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *In politics, image is everything. Faith is currency. And silence can be just as loud as belief.*
ACTRESS: *Meet Charlie Whitmore, a U.S. Senator who has spent his life saying the right words,*
ACTOR: *Praising the right values and defending the right laws.*
ACTRESS: *But when a tragedy strikes close to home and shatters the talking points he's stood behind for years, he begins to question:*
ACTOR: *What is the cost of belief when it's used only as armor?*
ACTRESS: *What is the cost of power when it refuses to change?*
ACTOR: *And what happens when one man dares to speak his heart to a system that survives on applause instead of truth.*
TOGETHER: *Church and State by Jason Odell Williams*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Alex darts by the door, phone to her ear, spots Charlie and enters.

ALEX: (Pg 10-11) *(into phone)* Never mind, I found him. Tell Security to stand down. *(hangs up)* Senator, what are you doing in here? You're due on stage in 15 minutes. (*He shuts off the TV. Paces, nervous)* You have no reason to be nervous, sir. It's the same speech you gave last week.

CHARLIE: Oh, I'm not nervous – I could do this speech without any teleprompters, one arm behind my back.

ALEX: Security said you were mumbling to yourself . . . acting strange, then just disappeared without a word. We circled the building five times looking for you.

CHARLIE: (Pg 12) Well, it's no big deal really, I was just - after this morning, at the thing there, it got me thinking again -- about the events of last week. . .

SARA: *(rushes in, all in one breath)* There you are baby we've been looking all over for you.

CHARLIE: . . . and it just occurred to me that maybe I shouldn't deliver the speech ***as written***, ya know. Word for word. But speak from the heart. About everything that's happened. And u . . . Yeah. That. *(beat)*

ALEX: (Pg 13) You don't ***change*** the speech that got you this far ***three*** days before the election.

CHARLIE: (Pg 14-15) *(to Alex and Sara)* Well, there's a, uh. Slight chance a story may come out about me on … Twitter or somewhere on the Internet and quote me sayin' some stuff about how, maybe, I don't quite uh . . . believe in God anymore.

SARA: You son of a . . . ! *(hits Charlie on the arm on each bold and italicized word)* Turning your back on ***Jesus***!? He's the one that helped get you ***elected*** in the first place! YOUR CAMPAIGN SONG IS "***JESUS*** IS MY RUNNING MATE!!!

CHARLIE: Would you please stop hitting me! And ***you're*** the one who picked that song, said donations would increase if we used it.

ALEX: (Pg 18) *(with a deadly smile)* Mrs. Whitmore, we've been thrilled to have your support throughout this campaign, but if you can't let your husband explain this possible crisis, I will seriously call security and have you escorted out of the building. . . *(Sara sarcastically "zips her lips while Alex gestures for Charlie to continue)* Senator . . .

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

CHARLIE: **(Pg 19)** Well, this morning, after the, uh . . . funeral. I'm standing out of the way and some guy comes up to me . . .

*****Flashback scene*****

MARSHALL: Beautiful service. *(offers hand to shake)* I'm Marshall, by the way. I'm an independent reporter.

ALEX: *(interjects)* Code for blogger . . .

MARSHALL: Mind if I . . . ask you a few questions? *(points a small digital recorder at Charlie, then launches into rapid fire questioning)* **(Pg 20)** Were you saddened by the news? Did you think about your own sons? Did you turn to prayer in your time of need?

CHARLIE: *(to audience)* And I don't know why. But it struck me as such a ... peculiar question. "Did I turn to ***prayer*** in ***my*** time of need." I mean, asking something so personal. At a funeral. And something in me just. . . snapped. So, I told the truth. *(to Marshall)* No. I did not. I did not turn to prayer . . .

SARA: *(interjects)* Oh, sweet Jesus.

CHARLIE: . . . These families don't need my prayers right now, son, they need my action. I'm a politician. And it's my duty to honor the victims by doing everything in my power to make sure this never happens again.

MARSHALL: **(Pg 21-22)** Do you . . . believe in God?

CHARLIE: ***What***?

MARSHALL: If you don't think prayers/will help the victims, I'm just wondering if you believe in God at all? *(Charlie pauses thoughtfully)*

ALEX: *(interjects)* Did you or did you not say you don't believe in God?!

CHARLIE: *(blurts to Alex)* I SAID, "HOW CAN YOU BELIEVE IN A GOD THAT WOULD ALLOW SOMETHING LIKE THIS TO HAPPEN?! *(pause, back to Marshall)* And continue to happen - over and over and over again! And I'm sorry, son, if I seem upset, but this was at a school. The school our boys go to. And it could have just as easily been ***their*** classroom that . . . *(growing incensed)* Some hotshot decided he'd make a name for himself by shooting up a classroom with an AR-15. So no, at this moment, I do not believe in a god that would allow

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

something like this to happen, and I will not waste my time with prayers when there is TOO MUCH WORK TO BE DONE!

*******End Flashback*******

SARA: *(panicking)* Oh my god oh my god oh my god. *(to Charlie)* If you're sayin' you wanna change your speech so you can tell all those decent, hardworkin', God-fearing people that their prayers are nothing but a "waste of time," then you will not only lose this election, but you'll be laughed out of politics.

CHARLIE: Okay, honey, calm down. It's no big deal.

ALEX: **(Pg 23-24)** *(looking at her phone)* Your new best friend tweeted "Senator Whitmore Speaks Out Against Guns, God and Prayer." And there are already twenty re-tweets, plus a dozen or so comments. This was posted two minutes ago. We need to walk this back, say you were grieving, the kid took your words out of context. If we don't get ahead of it, you're not only jeopardizing this election, but your entire future in politics!

CHARLIE: And what if I don't want to limit the damage?! *(beat)* **(Pg 27-28)** I was ... watching our friend throw dirt into his sons' graves. And we're all bowing our heads in prayer and I thought ... How's our prayer going to prevent another senseless shooting? And just when the pastor's saying "ashes to ashes," it hit me: what if this is it? Dust to dust, nothing ***waiting*** for us on the other side. Would that be any crazier then some man in the clouds "listening to our prayers"? What if God, the concept of God, was just created by us to cope with the pain and randomness and heartache of his miracle we call life? Wouldn't that mean we shouldn't be so hung up about what it says in ***my*** book versus ***your*** book, or feel the need to hold on to our outdated laws and ideals, ***especially*** the one that got us into this mess in the first place: our "God given right to bear arms?!"

ALEX: Whoa! Sir. All due respect, talking about God is one thing . . . but you ***cannot*** take on the 2nd Amendment. This story's bad enough. If you compound it by saying "***your guns are bad***," that'll be it for us! *(to Sara)* Please try to talk some sense into your husband. *(leaves)*

CHARLIE: **(Pg 29)** *(to Sara)* I thought the whole point of this country was to keep religion ***out*** of politics. It's in the first damn amendment.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SARA: We both know what's important to your voters: ***faith, family and football***. Same values they want to see in their politicians. *(takes a deep breath)* **(Pg 31-32)** Is what happened at our school wrong? Of course. It's horrifying and sick and impossible to live with -- which is why we need our Faith to help us through. Do we need to do something about guns? *(shrugs)* I don't know. Personally, I believe in my right to bear arms, and sure as heck don't want to give up my Baby Glock. But when you start talkin' all this craziness about there being no God, or prayer is useless then you have gone too far, Charlie Whitmore! So go splash some water on your face, give the speech you always give, and knock off this insanity!

CHARLIE: *(softly)* I saw it Sara. First-hand . . . the blood splattered around that classroom. On the chalkboard and the American flag. A group of crying 1st graders standing in a baseball field. Frightened parents sprinting under the yellow caution tape to find and hug their scared little children. No one should have to know that fear. No one. *(beat)* And that's my fault. Like it or not, my actions as Senator played a role in this tragedy. And the ones that came before it. How long and fiercely I fought to protect our "God-given right" to bear arms. *(beat)* This has to be addressed. Now.

SARA: You are not responsible for the 29 deaths last week. That was not your fault.

CHARLIE: Oh yeah, whose was it then?

SARA: That boy who went crazy!

CHARLIE: "Guns don't kill people," right?

SARAH: If it wasn't a gun at a school, it would have been a bomb at a hospital. You can't stop every single lunatic without taking away our freedoms. You can't just change your mind and expect me to support you. *(long beat)*

CHARLIE: **(Pg 33-34)** When did you start believing in God?

SARA: I've always believed, what are you talking . . .

CHARLIE: No, we don't come out of the womb "believing in Jesus." It's not instinct; we have to be taught. I learned about God when I was 6 years old at my daddy's funeral. They told me God had taken my daddy because "Heaven needed another angel." And I believed that. Church gave [us] structure and security . . . and hope. But you know what else I believed in

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

when I was 6 . . ? Santa Claus and the Easter Bunny.

SARA: Okay. I get it. I GET IT!

CHARLIE: *(continues over her with growing vehemence)* But then you realize that God is always watching, except when some hothead shoots up an elementary school. That was just ALL PART OF GOD'S MASTER PLAN, RIGHT?!! *(deep calming breath, then sadly)* That just makes me feel helpless. *(exits)*

******** Scene********

VOICE OVER: (Pg 38-39) So now, without further ado. Here he is. . . Raleigh's own . . . Senator Charles Whitmore!

CHARLIE: *(taking the stage)* Thank you for that warm introduction. *(to the crowd)* How are my fellow North Carolinians doing tonight? And don't tell me the score of the game, okay? I'm gonna watch it later and want to be surprised. *(then silence)* You all know me, right? You don't need to hear this same old speech again. *(rips his talking points in half)* You trust that I have your best interests at heart and would never steer you wrong.

FROM THE CROWD: AMEN!

CHARLIE: Ha, yes. "Amen." I'm glad you said that, because . . . Well. That's exactly what I wanna talk about tonight. *(pause)* God --

******** Scene********

REPORTER 2: *(upbeat)* In what can only be described as a landslide, Senator Whitmore will walk away with 71% of the popular vote. A roller-coaster weekend for the campaign: first a story that appeared on Twitter. Then that now-famous speech that stunned a packed auditorium who gave the senator very little applause when he left the stage. But the speech went viral, 2 million views in the first 24 hours alone. And that of course led to tonight, with the campaign celebrating! Turnout to be over 10,000!

*******Scene*******

ALEX: (Pg 45) *(ecstatic and celebratory)* . . . Senator, you did something unheard of: you got people on both sides to vote for you. The liberals want you to take on the gun lobby, the conservatives want to help you find your way back to God! They realized you were more

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

interested in principles than towing the party line. Voting for your idea: that living without fear is more important than religion or guns or antiquated laws. **(Pg 47)** [Now] deliver your acceptance speech as written – with confidence, humility and no specifics – Just a few bland platitudes about a brighter future.

CHARLIE: **(Pg 52)** *(on TV)* Thank you! Thank you all so much! And thank you for ***believing*** in me – believing that we ***all*** can make a difference . . . *(three distinct gunshots ring out and Charlie responds to being hit – long beat)*

REPORTER 2: *(solemnly)* At 7:52 PM while Senator Charles Whitmore was delivering his acceptance speech to a packed crowd, an unidentified gunman fired three shots at the Senator who was rushed to the hospital and pronounced dead on arrival.

REPORTER: The gunman, who used a TEC-22 semi-automatic handgun was apprehended by police . . .

REPORTER 2: The shooter has been identified as a 19-year-old student with no history of mental illness. . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jason Odell Williams
ISBN: 978-0822237624
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service
Date (Month/Year): 2017

AWARD HISTORY

NIETOC
IN State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY